

is complicated and requires constant knowledge improvement. Jain says, “We have to constantly upgrade our knowledge. It’s part of our job to carry out external reading. Everyday we spend close to 20 per cent of our work time on online forums and e-books. It takes a long time, about 4-6 years, to become specialised in this field.”

However, that doesn’t mean a slow growth in salary or promotions. Jain says, “For two years you remain at the base level, as a junior engineer. While the salary differs from company to company, usually one starts at Rs. 3–4 lakh per annum. In four years, you reach the mid-level and in eight years one can become a Senior Developer. Even though there is a difference in designations, the industry is quite flat. There are fewer managers than in other industries.”

He thinks it is a good industry for those who want to keep learning about technology and earn good money. What reassures him about the industry is the fact that there are so many big firms who are there in the field and they are continuing to invest. The number of clients is increasing and hence he is hopeful. He adds, “The added bonus is that the job doesn’t really ever get monotonous. At least until now it hasn’t. Maybe if you stick to a particular product line, then it can get boring. Then again, you wouldn’t learn more about a product line until you are in it for a while. Hence what is required to stick to this industry is a strong grounding in programming, algorithms, a willingness to learn and patience.”

From the employer

Gaurav Makkar works as a Senior Engineer at NetApp, one of the market leaders in the server virtualisation business. His function involves working as a researcher and a network architect in the firm. Even though he has been in the technology sector for over 14 years now, he has only been around in the field of virtualisation for less than two years, almost as old as the industry itself.

So what can one do to be part of this industry, which is going to completely alter the way we look at storing our data? Makkar says, “There is no buzzword at the entry level. We just look for a sound educational background. One should be good at computers, analytics and programming. A good software engineer will do. We largely pick up freshers as there are very few industries that build the kind of skills we are looking for.”

But apart from this, Makkar says that after a while the industry does look at specialisations, “For example, a program developer must be good at MS architecture or OS architecture. Then we do need core developers and engineers and for every 10 core engineers, we also need 100 application engineers.”

One of the greatest strengths of this industry, he thinks, is its relatively flat nature. “When you start out in this industry, you join as a member of technical staff (MTS) and your interaction with your seniors in the firm is not based on hierarchy. Rather, even today, my role is not to lead a team. I am a senior engineer, but my role is that of an individual architect and researcher. It gives me the space to work better without thinking about the politics around work. There are managers who are on a different vertical. So while our job is to provide the server solutions, it is the manager’s job to see to it that the implementation is done efficiently.” For those who want to join the management, there is that option too. Once one crosses the level of a senior manager, the choice is offered.

Face-2-Face with Employer

“It is still early days. Very few people actually know about this phenomenon, even though it can be a huge cost-saver. While virtualising, sometimes we found firms where some servers were not even being used to 10 per cent of their capacity. There are just so many improvements that are possible in so many firms.””

Gaurav Makkar
Senior Engineer
NetApp